

Module 3: Religion, Ethics, and Migration

Signature Learning Experience

Purpose

Students confront a real moral dilemma in migration — one with no comfortable answer — and analyze it rigorously through at least two ethical frameworks. The goal is disciplined moral reasoning: understanding why thoughtful people disagree, not producing the 'right' answer.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Describe ethical perspectives accurately, including ones you reject (UG 1)
- Explain religious influences on migration ethics where relevant to the case (UG 2)
- Analyze a moral dilemma without collapsing it into a slogan (UG 3)

Graduate extension

Graduate students critically evaluate the frameworks themselves — where does each framework break down under this case? — and connect the dilemma to a live policy debate with scholarly sources (Grad 1–2).

Assignment steps

1. Select one dilemma from the provided case bank (e.g., a mayor deciding on sanctuary policy under state pressure; a border officer and a family with a weak asylum claim; a church congregation sheltering someone with a removal order) or propose your own for approval.
2. State the dilemma precisely: who must decide, what the options are, and what each option costs — if one side has no real cost, it is not a dilemma; sharpen it.
3. Analyze the case through two frameworks from the module (e.g., rights-based ethics, consequentialism, Catholic social teaching / ethics of hospitality, communitarianism).
4. Show where the frameworks converge and where they give opposing guidance.
5. State your own reasoned position and its strongest counterargument — you are graded on the counterargument's strength, not your conclusion.
6. Discuss the case in the seminar session before submitting the final written analysis.

Deliverables & format

- Written case analysis, 1,500–1,800 words (graduate: 2,500 with framework critique and policy connection)
- Case statement box (150 words) that a classmate could understand cold
- Minimum 4 module sources (graduate: 8 including 4 peer-reviewed)

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Precision of the dilemma statement 15%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: precision of the dilemma statement goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: precision of the dilemma statement is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: precision of the dilemma statement is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: precision of the dilemma statement is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Accurate, fair application of both frameworks 35%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: accurate, fair application of both frameworks goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: accurate, fair application of both frameworks is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: accurate, fair application of both frameworks is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: accurate, fair application of both frameworks is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.
Strength of the counterargument to your own position 25%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: strength of the counterargument to your own position goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: strength of the counterargument to your own position is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: strength of the counterargument to your own position is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: strength of the counterargument to your own position is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Use of course concepts and sources 15%	Evidence and accuracy are exemplary: use of course concepts and sources is met with high-quality, correctly cited sources for every substantive claim; terms, facts, and frameworks are used precisely.	Evidence and accuracy are solid: use of course concepts and sources is met for nearly all claims, with only minor sourcing gaps or imprecisions that do not affect conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are uneven: use of course concepts and sources is partly met — some claims lack support, sources are thin or misread, or terms are used loosely in ways that weaken conclusions.	Evidence and accuracy are deficient: use of course concepts and sources is not met; key claims are unsupported or wrong, and errors undermine the work's conclusions.
Clarity of writing 10%	Communication is publication-ready: clarity of writing is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: clarity of writing is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: clarity of writing is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: clarity of writing is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.